

Small Town Suspects

Mrs Bennet meets *Swami and Friends*? It's a comic masterpiece but only if one enjoys Tamil humour of the very broad kind.



WHITE MAN FALLING
by MIKE STOCKS
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 250
Pages: 304

■ By Geeta Doctor

Imagine plucking Mrs Bennet out of her conventional English countryside and planting her in Madurai in rural Tamil Nadu. Provide her with six nubile daughters, an ability to peel garlic at top speed and perform morning prayers in such a manner as to draw the envy of neighbours since that's not how members of her Thevar community observe their rituals. Amma, as she is called, however, is a character. For she has to contend with Mr Bennet, her husband, Swami, a retired sub-inspector, whose full name is R.M. Swaminathan, who is partially paralysed and is about to suffer the misfortune falling upon him as hinted by the title.

Mike Stocks has succeeded in performing a feat of sorts. He has stir-fried a tale of domestic drama and murky goings-on in the police department of Mullaipuram, which could be a doppelganger for Madurai, by stretching the marriage proposal of the elder of the Swami daughters, called Jodhi,

into the kind of Tamil small screen serial that keeps such families secure in the hearth peeling garlic, making idlis and studying the horoscopes of prospective candidates who like Jodhi's intended, Mohan, are aiming to become wizards in the IT industry. That is to say, so far so trite, comparisons to Mrs Bennet notwithstanding.

Let us put in a word about names. Stocks makes a big thing about the Thevar background of the family. This is not surprising, since the Thevars are politically on the rise in the heartland of Tamil Nadu. Whether it is

because of this upward mobility that Stocks has named Mr Bennet Swaminathan, an upper caste name, or whether he is winking in the direction of R.K. Narayan's *Swami and Friends*, or more to the point Swaminathan's apotheosis from inert husband and father to internationally famous holy man, or Swamiji, as in *The Guide*, can be debated.

What cannot be doubted is that it's all a bit contrived. Stocks knows his Madurai well. When Swami becomes the Swamiji and is transported to a hill station, which is a replica of Kodaikanal, you realise he knows his Kodaikanal too in intimate detail. He gives you a potted history, complete with his personal comments about viewing platforms for tourists that double as garbage dumps, hairpin bends and moments of charged beauty that allow the Swamiji and his followers to

commune with each other. He's parlayed his knowledge of the territory well enough to make it his own. Since the author's note says he also writes adventure thrillers, one can only suppose that this is a milder version of a thriller, since there is a putative murder, a cover-up and Swami's own trajectory from life to death and back that provides an out-of-body mystic sequence that Stocks handles with sufficient brio to make it mildly interesting. Is it the comic masterpiece that it's touted to be? Only if you like characters who say, "Aiyayo Swami" and "Adda-adai, adai!" in that comic Tamil way. ■



SAURABH SINGH

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